communication and logistics in the next three years, Gen. Rawat sent a structure to the three services for their views in November 2021. According to his plan, the armed forces were to be reorganised into five commands. He was to announce the theatre commands by the end of 2022. It was at this juncture that tragedy struck—on December 8, 2021, Gen. Rawat died in a helicopter crash, taking with him the impetus on the issue. Since then, plans for theatrisation have, for all intents and purposes, been on the backburner. It seemed for a while that a tussle amongst the services over command and control vis-à-vis such jointness had gotten the better of any urgency over the matter. There was also resistance to theatrisation within the military over technical matters, most often raised by the Indian Air Force (IAF), which is loath to see the division of its air assets. It is also felt that there is lack of political will on the matter, and that the government is now more invested in implementing the Agniveer recruitment process.

Finally, nearly 10 months after Gen. Rawat's death, the government appointed Lt Gen. (retd) Anil Chauhan as the second CDS. Lt Gen. Chauhan assumed office on October 1 and is yet to spell out his action plan regarding theatrisation. Though in his first official communication to the three services, Gen. Chauhan asked them to move forward with the creation of integrated theatre commands, no visible movement is seen. Military planners now believe that the process will be "deliberate, thoughtful and well-considered".



ANI

TRAGIC LOSS
The helicopter crash that killed Gen. Bipin Rawat, his wife and others on Dec. 8, 2021

THE IAF, WHICH OPERATES MULTI-ROLE FIGHTERS, IS RELUCTANT TO DIVIDE SCARCE ASSETS. EXPERTS SAY **MORE WORK NEEDS TO BE DONE** BEFORE ADOPTING A FOREIGN CONCEPT LIKE THEATRISATION

Five Theatre Commands

The Indian military currently functions under 17 single-service commands: the army and IAF have seven commands each, and the navy has three. Gen. Rawat's plan had envisaged a reorganisation into five commands—eastern, western, peninsular, air defence and maritime—along the lines of the US and Chinese armed forces. The Pakistan-centric western theatre command would extend from Indira Col on Siachen Glacier to Gujarat, with its expected headquarters in Jaipur. The China-specific eastern theatre command would cover the entire 3,488 km of the Line of Actual Control, starting from the icy heights of Ladakh to Kibithu in Arunachal Pradesh and is to be headquartered in Lucknow. These two commands will be land commands and are expected to be led by senior army officers. The proposed peninsular command, responsible for any future operations in the Indian Ocean Region, will be based in Thiruvananthapuram. The maritime command will be based in Karwar, India's biggest naval base, and will have all naval assets of the current western and eastern naval commands along with two brigades of the army (the Thiruvananthapuram-based 91 Brigade and the Port Blair-based 108 Mountain Brigade) and two squadrons of maritime strike jets. It will be responsible for defending India's maritime boundary. The air defence command at Prayagraj will be responsible for protecting military assets from airborne attack and will have the air assets of all the three services, as well as land-based missile defence systems like the S400. Apart from fighter jets of the IAF, it will control anti-aircraft missiles and air defence guns of the army and the navy. It will be headed by the senior-most three-star officer of the IAF. Gen. Rawat had also planned two functional commands—joint training command and operational logistics command, to meet the operational needs of the theatre commands.

Opposition from IAF, other criticism

The most sustained opposition to theatrisation has come from the IAF, especially regarding the air defence command (ADC), which aims to put all of the military's air defence assets under one umbrella. The IAF says that an ADC will stretch and divide its resources, given that it operates only 30 combat squadrons, as against a sanctioned 42. Moreover, during a